VOLUME 2

Reader Questions

Questions on Difficult Bible Verses



READERS QUESTION SERIES

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HOW TO READ THIS VOLUME

Each entry takes one question a reader has asked about one verse or short passage. It states what the verse means, and then argues that meaning from the verse's own passage and the chapter or chapters before it. The Scripture elsewhere is used as support, not as the foundation. Each entry marks what the text states, what the context shows, and what is inferred, so that the reader can see what carries the weight and judge it. The entries argue a position. Where other readings are held by named writers, they are set beside it with the places where each strains.

Scripture is quoted from the King James Version (KJV). Modern writers are named by author and work; their views are described in the entry's own words, and no quotation marks are used for them.

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1. Who Is “Taken” and Who Is “Left” in Matthew 24:40–41?

THE ANSWER

The one “taken” is taken away in judgment, as the flood “took them all away,” and the one “left” remains to enter the kingdom. The passage is Israel’s separation at the Lord’s coming, spoken to disciples on the Mount of Olives. It is not the gathering of the Body.

Where the Verse Stands

Matthew 24 answers a question put by the disciples “privately” on the mount of Olives: “what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?” (24:3). The answer speaks of “this gospel of the kingdom” (24:14), of Judaea and the holy place (24:15–16) and of a flight that must not fall on “the sabbath day” (24:20). The words about two in the field and two at the mill close that answer, and they are tied by the word “as” to the days of Noah.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
24:3	“And as he sat upon the mount of Olives, the disciples came unto him privately, saying, Tell us, when shall these things be? and what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?”	Disciples ask about “thy coming” and “the end of the world.”
24:37–41	“But as the days of Noah were, so shall also the coming of the Son of man be. For as in the days that were before the flood they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until the day that Noe entered into the ark, And knew not until the flood came, and took them all away; so shall also the coming of the Son of man be. Then shall two be in the field; the one shall be taken, and the other left. Two women shall be grinding at the mill; the one shall be taken, and the other left.”	The flood “took them all away.” Then one is “taken,” one “left.”
Luke 17:34–37	“I tell you, in that night there shall be two men in one bed; the one shall be taken, and the other shall be left. Two women shall be grinding together; the one shall be taken, and the other left. Two men shall be in the field; the one shall be taken, and the other left. And they answered and said unto him, Where, Lord? And he said unto them, Wheresoever the body is, thither will the eagles be gathered together.”	The same sayings; the disciples ask “Where, Lord?” The answer is the body and the eagles.
25:34	“Then shall the King say unto them on his right hand, Come, ye blessed of my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world:”	Those on the right hand “inherit the kingdom.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the comparison is to Noah: the people "knew not until the flood came, and took them all away; so shall also the coming of the Son of man be." The one who is "taken" in the comparison is taken by the flood.
- **Stated:** in Luke's form the disciples ask where, and the answer is "Wheresoever the body is, thither will the eagles be gathered together," which is the picture of judgment on the dead.
- **Shown by the context:** the audience and setting are Israel's: the disciples ask about the kingdom age, Judaea, the holy place and the sabbath. Nothing in the chapter is addressed to a company called out of the nations.
- **Shown by the context:** the ones who are left are the ones who go on to the kingdom. In the next chapter the King says to those on his right hand, "inherit the kingdom prepared for you" (25:34).
- **Inferred:** that "taken" in 24:40–41 carries the sense it has in 24:39. The Greek verb is a different one in the two places, so the argument rests on the comparison the Lord himself draws, not on the word.

The Other Readings

The one taken is gathered to the Lord. This is the popular reading, and it takes the sayings as a picture of the gathering of the church. It reads "taken" as received, as in John 14:3, "I will come again, and receive you unto myself." It must explain why the comparison with the flood, in which the ones taken are the ones destroyed, gives the opposite result, and why a chapter spoken to the disciples about Judaea and the sabbath is turned to a company that has no such setting. **The one taken is taken in judgment.** Stanley Toussaint (*Behold the King*) takes the sayings this way, and so do many who hold that the gathering of the Body comes before the tribulation, since this reading finds no gathering of the Body in Matthew 24. That is the reading taken here, and the entry argues it from the flood comparison and the chapter's own audience.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Taken to the Lord	The one taken is received, as in John 14:3.	The flood comparison reverses it; the audience and setting are Israel's.
Taken in judgment	The one taken is removed as the flood removed the unprepared.	The verb differs between verses 39 and 40–41.

What It Means for the Reader

The sayings are a warning about readiness at the Lord's coming, and a reader who takes them as a promise of the Body's gathering has taken the wrong end of the comparison. The gathering of the Body is described elsewhere, in words of comfort: "the dead in Christ shall rise first: Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds" (1 Thessalonians 4:16–17).

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 29, One Taken and the Other Left, reports the sayings as written and states the Israel-separation reading as the text's setting; this entry argues the position through the flood comparison. **Commentary Series:** Typology, Volume 2 (Prophetic Separation), and Gospel, Volume 3 (The Olivet Discourse). **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew and Luke.

2. Who Is “the Israel of God” in Galatians 6:16?

THE ANSWER

“The Israel of God” is believing Israel: the prophetic remnant of ethnic Jews who have embraced Messiah and remain members of Israel’s Prophecy Program, within Israel’s prophetic identity, named beside the Body and not as the Body. They are not absorbed into the Body, and their identity, destiny and program membership stay intact. Paul gives peace to “as many as walk according to this rule,” and mercy also “upon the Israel of God.” The phrase is a benediction on Jewish believers who walk by the rule just stated. The Body is not Israel, and Israel is not the Body.

Where the Verse Stands

The letter closes against men who “constrain you to be circumcised” so that they may glory in the flesh (6:12–13). Paul answers with the cross and with one standard: in Christ “neither circumcision availeth any thing, nor uncircumcision, but a new creature.” The blessing of verse 16 is the last word of the argument. The question is whether it names one company or two.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2:7–9	“But contrariwise, when they saw that the gospel of the uncircumcision was committed unto me, as the gospel of the circumcision was unto Peter; (For he that wrought effectually in Peter to the apostleship of the circumcision, the same was mighty in me toward the Gentiles:) And when James, Cephas, and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that was given unto me, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship; that we should go unto the heathen, and they unto the circumcision.”	Two ministries, two fields, by agreement.
6:12–13	“As many as desire to make a fair shew in the flesh, they constrain you to be circumcised; only lest they should suffer persecution for the cross of Christ. For neither they themselves who are circumcised keep the law; but desire to have you circumcised, that they may glory in your flesh.”	The opponents compel circumcision for their own glory.
6:14–16	“But God forbid that I should glory, save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ, by whom the world is crucified unto me, and I unto the world. For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision availeth any thing, nor uncircumcision, but a new creature. And as many as walk according to this rule, peace be on them, and mercy, and upon the Israel of God.”	Peace on those who walk by the rule; mercy also on the Israel of God.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the blessing has two parts: "peace be on them, and mercy, and upon the Israel of God." Those who "walk according to this rule" are the ones addressed; the Israel of God is named after them.
- **Stated:** Paul's own use of "Israel" elsewhere is for the nation. He speaks of "Israelites" as his "kinsmen according to the flesh" (Romans 9:3–4). He never uses the word of Gentiles in this letter or in any other.
- **Shown by the context:** the letter is written against Jewish teachers who would add circumcision, so the reader must hold in mind Jewish believers who did not follow them. The blessing sets those who walk by the rule beside the believing Jews who are Israel by identity, and neither is asked to become the other.
- **Shown by the context:** the letter has just said that "neither Jew nor Greek" is a division in Christ (3:28), yet Paul still speaks in 2:7–9 of a gospel of the circumcision and a gospel of the uncircumcision. The unity is in Christ; the two fields remain.
- **Inferred:** that the Israel of God is believing Israel, the remnant of ethnic Jews who have embraced Messiah, within Israel's prophetic identity and not members of the Body. The text does not describe their program, and the argument rests on Paul's use of the name and the two-part blessing. The Body is not Israel, and Israel is not the Body.

The Other Readings

The church, the new Israel. Many commentators read the phrase as the whole company of believers, Jew and Gentile, as S. Lewis Johnson's survey of the question records. The reading has the "and" of verse 16 explaining the first group, and it has to carry a name Paul uses for the nation everywhere else onto a company the letter itself says is "neither Jew nor Greek." **Jewish believers.** Ernest De Witt Burton (*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Epistle to the Galatians*) and Hans Dieter Betz (*Galatians*, Hermeneia) take the phrase as Jewish believers in distinction from the Gentile majority. S. Lewis Johnson ("Paul and 'the Israel of God,'" in *Essays in Honor of J. Dwight Pentecost*) judges that reading sound though weaker, and argues instead that the phrase names the nation of Israel. The Jewish-believers reading is the one taken here. The Gentile believer is never called "Israel" or "spiritual Israel," and the entry does not use either name.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
The church (new Israel)	One company, with "and" explaining.	Paul uses "Israel" for the nation; the letter dissolves Jew and Greek in Christ, not Israel.
Believing Israel	Two companies, named in order.	The text does not state their program.

What It Means for the Reader

Galatians 6:16 does not turn the Gentile believer into Israel. It also does not hand the Body the promises given to Israel. The standing sentence of the letter is that "the seed is prophetic fulfillment in Christ; the Body receives blessing through Christ alone, not through participation in the Abrahamic covenant." The same passage that says "ye are all one in Christ Jesus" (3:28) does not erase the nation Paul loves.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 35, Who Is the Israel of God?, reports the verse as written; this entry argues who the phrase names. **Commentary Series:** Covenantal, Volume 2

(Abraham's Seed), and Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 1. **Doctrinal Packets:** Galatians.

3. Is the Great Commission Given to the Body of Christ?

THE ANSWER

The commission of Matthew 28:18–20 was spoken to the eleven on a mountain in Galilee, after Matthew 10 sent them to "the lost sheep of the house of Israel." It widens the field to the nations and ties the work to the kingdom commands and "the end of the world." The Body's commission is Paul's, the ministry of reconciliation, and Paul says Christ "sent me not to baptize."

Where the Verse Stands

The commission closes Matthew. Its first hearers are named: "the eleven disciples," in "a mountain where Jesus had appointed them." Eighteen chapters earlier the same men were sent out with a narrower charge. The passage cannot be read as if no earlier commission stood behind it.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Mt 10:5–7	"These twelve Jesus sent forth, and commanded them, saying, Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not: But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. And as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand."	The Twelve: not to the Gentiles, but to Israel, preaching the kingdom "at hand."
Mt 28:16–20	"Then the eleven disciples went away into Galilee, into a mountain where Jesus had appointed them. And when they saw him, they worshipped him: but some doubted. And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world. Amen."	The eleven. "All nations." Baptizing. "All things whatsoever I have commanded you." "The end of the world."
Acts 1:6–8	"When they therefore were come together, they asked of him, saying, Lord, wilt thou at this time restore again the kingdom to Israel? And he said unto them, It is not for you to know the times or the seasons, which the Father hath put in his own power. But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth."	The question is the kingdom for Israel. The witness runs from Jerusalem outward.

1 Cor 1:17	“For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel: not with wisdom of words, lest the cross of Christ should be made of none effect.”	Paul: Christ “sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel.”
2 Cor 5:18–20	“And all things are of God, who hath reconciled us to himself by Jesus Christ, and hath given to us the ministry of reconciliation; To wit, that God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them; and hath committed unto us the word of reconciliation. Now then we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us: we pray you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God.”	Paul’s commission: “the ministry of reconciliation,” “ambassadors for Christ.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the audience is “the eleven disciples,” and the place is the one “where Jesus had appointed them.” The commission is given to those men.
- **Stated:** the content to be taught is “all things whatsoever I have commanded you,” and what the Lord had commanded these men is recorded in this Gospel from the Sermon on the Mount to chapter 24.
- **Shown by the context:** the earlier commission (10:5–7) sends the Twelve to Israel only. The new commission names “all nations,” so the field widens, while the work stays that of the kingdom the Twelve had been sent to announce.
- **Shown by the context:** the book of Acts opens with the same men asking, “wilt thou at this time restore again the kingdom to Israel?” The Lord does not correct the question; he speaks of times and seasons and sends them as witnesses, beginning in Jerusalem.
- **Inferred:** that “the end of the world” is the same age Matthew has been speaking of, as in 24:3. The Greek word is the same in both places, so the promise “I am with you always” runs through the age that ends with the kingdom, not through a different one.

The Other Readings

The charter of the church. Many commentaries read the passage as the standing mission of all the Lord’s people to the end of the age, and many draw the church’s method from it. This reading must carry to the Body a commission whose terms include baptizing and the keeping of the kingdom commands, while Paul says Christ “sent me not to baptize.” **The commission of the Twelve.** This is the reading taken here. It leaves the Body its own commission, the one Paul names: “the ministry of reconciliation,” given to those who are “ambassadors for Christ.” Paul never repeats the commission of Matthew 28 and never commands baptism, and he is not recorded placing the Body under the kingdom commands.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
The church’s charter	Matthew 28 sets the method for every age.	Paul’s separate commission and his words on baptism.
The commission of the Twelve	The eleven are sent to disciple the nations under the Lord’s commands.	The Body’s witness must stand on Paul’s commission.

What It Means for the Reader

The Body is not without a commission; it is not Matthew 28. Its commission is the ministry of reconciliation, given through Paul, whose apostleship to the Gentiles is what he calls his “office.” A reader who reads Matthew 28 as the Body’s charter takes over baptism and the kingdom commands that Paul does not command.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 66, Matthew 28:18–20, reports the passage as written; this entry argues who it was given to, and Study 18 sets the two commissions side by side. **Commentary Series:** Acts, Volume 1 (What the Twelve Were Told, and Did), and Gospel, Volume 2. **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew and Acts.

4. Is Water Baptism Required for the Body's Salvation?

THE ANSWER

No. The Body is saved by grace through faith, and its one baptism is the work of the Spirit, "by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body." The passages that join water to salvation are spoken in Israel's setting, where baptism attends the kingdom message. Even there the sentence that condemns names unbelief and not an unbaptized state.

Where the Verses Stand

Four passages are set against the answer: Mark 16:16, Acts 22:16, 1 Peter 3:21 and the "buried with him in baptism" of Romans 6 and Colossians 2. Each has its own speaker, hearers and setting. Against them stand Paul's plain statement that salvation is "not of works" and his statement that Christ "sent me not to baptize."

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Mk 1:4	"John did baptize in the wilderness, and preach the baptism of repentance for the remission of sins."	John's baptism: "of repentance for the remission of sins," to Israel.
Mk 16:15–18	"And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature. He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned. And these signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils; they shall speak with new tongues; They shall take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them; they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover."	Spoken to the eleven. Signs follow. The condemnation is for the one who "believeth not."
Acts 22:14–16	"And he said, The God of our fathers hath chosen thee, that thou shouldest know his will, and see that Just One, and shouldest hear the voice of his mouth. For thou shalt be his witness unto all men of what thou hast seen and heard. And now why tarriest thou? arise, and be baptized, and wash away thy sins, calling on the name of the Lord."	Ananias, "the God of our fathers." The words are an instruction to Saul in Damascus.

1 Pet 3:20–21	"Which sometime were disobedient, when once the longsuffering of God waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was a preparing, wherein few, that is, eight souls were saved by water. The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us (not the putting away of the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God,) by the resurrection of Jesus Christ:"	Written to "strangers scattered." The "answer of a good conscience," not "the filth of the flesh."
1 Cor 1:17	"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel: not with wisdom of words, lest the cross of Christ should be made of none effect."	Paul: "sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel."
1 Cor 12:13	"For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body, whether we be Jews or Gentiles, whether we be bond or free; and have been all made to drink into one Spirit."	Spirit baptism "into one body," Jews and Gentiles, in the one act.
Eph 2:8–9	"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast."	"By grace are ye saved through faith … not of works."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Mark 16:16 has two halves, and the second half does not repeat baptism: "he that believeth not shall be damned." The ground of condemnation is unbelief.
- **Stated:** Paul says the Body's salvation is "by grace … through faith" and "not of works," and separately that Christ "sent me not to baptize."
- **Shown by the context:** Mark 16 is spoken to the eleven, with signs following (16:17–18). Acts 22:16 is Ananias, "a devout man according to the law" (22:12), speaking to Saul before Paul's own ministry began. First Peter 1:1 is addressed to the scattered of the circumcision's apostle. In each place the speaker and hearer are in Israel's line, where baptism went with the message of the kingdom.
- **Shown by the context:** Ephesians 4:5 counts "one baptism" in the list that includes "one body, and one Spirit." In that list the baptism is the one that makes the body, which 1 Corinthians 12:13 names.
- **Inferred:** that Romans 6:3–4 and Colossians 2:11–12 describe that same Spirit baptism, since Colossians calls it "the circumcision made without hands." The two letters do not say whether the water is meant, and the argument rests on that phrase.
- **Inferred:** that Mark 16:9–20, which the oldest manuscripts leave out, adds nothing the other passages do not carry. The entry does not rest on the textual question.

The Other Readings

Baptism as the moment of washing. The readings that make water the means of cleansing take Acts 22:16 and 1 Peter 3:21 at their plainest. Some read baptism in the New Testament as the place where the washing and the calling on the Lord's name come together. They must explain why Paul, whose gospel is the gospel of grace, says baptism was not his commission, and why 1 Peter 3:21 itself says the water is not what saves. **Baptism as a sign of faith already present.** Others take baptism as a sign of faith already present, for every believer in every age. That is nearer the reading taken here but carries the practice from Israel's setting into the Body's. **Spirit baptism only.** This is the reading for the Body argued here. Israel's baptism (John's, the Great

Commission's, Peter's in early Acts) is a program requirement, never a ground of salvation.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Water saves	Water baptism is the point of washing.	1 Corinthians 1:17; Ephesians 2:8–9; 1 Peter 3:21 itself.
A sign for every believer	Baptism follows faith in every age.	Carries Israel's practice to the Body.
Spirit baptism for the Body	The Body's baptism is the Spirit's; Israel's water belongs to its program.	Romans 6 and Colossians 2 do not say which baptism.

What It Means for the Reader

The Body's hope does not wait on water. A reader may be baptized in water out of obedience or conscience, and the passage does not forbid it, but the reader should not read the Lord's words to the eleven, or Ananias's words to Saul, as a condition laid on the Body.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 42, One Baptism, and Study 20, Understanding Acts 2:38, report the passages as written; this entry argues the answer. **Commentary Series:** Acts, Volume 2 (The Spirit in Acts). **Doctrinal Packets:** Mark, Acts and Ephesians.

5. Can a Believer Lose Salvation According to Hebrews 6:4–6?

THE ANSWER

No, because the passage is not a warning to the Body. Hebrews is written to Israel, and the warning is Israel's danger of rejecting the Messiah after receiving the kingdom's signs ("the powers of the world to come"), which is to crucify the Son afresh. The Body's security rests on promises the passage never touches: "neither death, nor life … shall be able to separate us."

Where the Verses Stand

Hebrews 5:11 to 6:12 is one argument. The writer rebukes the readers for being "dull of hearing" and in need of milk, urges them to leave "the principles of the doctrine of Christ," and in the middle of that urging gives the sentence about those who fall away. It ends with a turn: "But, beloved, we are persuaded better things of you."

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2:3–4	"How shall we escape, if we neglect so great salvation; which at the first began to be spoken by the Lord, and was confirmed unto us by them that heard him; God also bearing them witness, both with signs and wonders, and with divers miracles, and gifts of the Holy Ghost, according to his own will?"	The message was confirmed by "signs and wonders, and with divers miracles, and gifts of the Holy Ghost."
3:1	"Wherefore, holy brethren, partakers of the heavenly calling, consider the Apostle and High Priest of our profession, Christ Jesus;"	"Holy brethren, partakers of the heavenly calling."
5:11–12	"Of whom we have many things to say, and hard to be uttered, seeing ye are dull of hearing. For when for the time ye ought to be teachers, ye have need that one teach you again which be the first principles of the oracles of God; and are become such as have need of milk, and not of strong meat."	They should be teachers and need milk.
6:1–2	"Therefore leaving the principles of the doctrine of Christ, let us go on unto perfection; not laying again the foundation of repentance from dead works, and of faith toward God, Of the doctrine of baptisms, and of laying on of hands, and of resurrection of the dead, and of eternal judgment."	The "principles": repentance, baptisms, laying on of hands, resurrection, judgment.

6:4–6	“For it is impossible for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and were made partakers of the Holy Ghost, And have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come, If they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance; seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put him to an open shame.”	“Impossible … to renew them again unto repentance” for those who “fall away.”
6:7–9	“For the earth which drinketh in the rain that cometh oft upon it, and bringeth forth herbs meet for them by whom it is dressed, receiveth blessing from God: But that which beareth thorns and briers is rejected, and is nigh unto cursing; whose end is to be burned. But, beloved, we are persuaded better things of you, and things that accompany salvation, though we thus speak.”	Earth that bears thorns is “nigh unto cursing.” Then: “better things of you.”
Rom 8:38–39	“For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.”	Nothing “shall be able to separate us from the love of God.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the sentence is conditional and its subject is described by what they received: enlightened, tasted of the heavenly gift, partakers of the Holy Ghost, tasted the good word and the powers of the world to come. The consequence is stated for “if they shall fall away.”
- **Stated:** the writer closes the argument with “better things … and things that accompany salvation, though we thus speak” (6:9). The warning is not spoken as a verdict on the readers.
- **Shown by the context:** the “principles” they are urged to leave are the elementary teachings of Israel’s practice (6:1–2): baptisms, the laying on of hands, resurrection and judgment. The readers are being pressed to go on, and the chapter’s argument is that to turn back after Christ is to join those who “crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh.”
- **Shown by the context:** the letter’s covenant is the one quoted in chapter 8 from Jeremiah 31, which belongs to the house of Israel and the house of Judah. The Body is not a party to that covenant.
- **Shown by the context:** the experiences listed in 6:4–5 match the kingdom signs recorded in 2:3–4: “signs and wonders, and with divers miracles, and gifts of the Holy Ghost.” “The powers of the world to come” are the powers of the coming kingdom, given to Israel as a foretaste.
- **Inferred:** that “fall away” means turning from the Messiah after those signs, whether by a return to the old system or by rejecting him, and not a loss of the Body’s salvation. The word is used once in the New Testament, and the argument rests on the letter’s own setting.
- **Inferred:** that the Body’s question is answered elsewhere. Paul tells the Ephesians they were “sealed with that holy Spirit of promise, which is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession” (Ephesians 1:13–14).

The Other Readings

True believers can fall and be lost. I. Howard Marshall (*Kept by the Power of God*) argues that the passage describes real believers who may forfeit salvation by persistent apostasy. It has the strongest literal fit with "once enlightened" and "partakers of the Holy Ghost," and it must set Hebrews 6 against Romans 8:38–39 and Ephesians 1:13–14. **The people were never saved.** Wayne Grudem (*Systematic Theology*) takes the language as describing those who share the blessings of the community without a true saving faith. It protects the security of the believer but strains the phrase "partakers of the Holy Ghost." **Believers who lose reward and maturity.** Zane Hodges ("Hebrews," in *The Bible Knowledge Commentary*) reads the passage as a warning to real believers of loss of reward. **A warning to Israel against rejecting the Messiah after the kingdom signs.** This is the reading taken here: a real warning in a real setting, tied to Israel's prophetic privileges, not one that reaches the Body's standing.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Real believers lose salvation	The warning describes forfeiture.	Romans 8:38–39; Ephesians 1:13–14.
Never saved	The warning describes professing members.	"Partakers of the Holy Ghost" and "better things … that accompany salvation."
Loss of reward or maturity	The warning describes discipline.	"Impossible … to renew them again unto repentance."
Israel, after the kingdom signs	A warning against rejecting the Messiah.	The letter does not name its readers outright.

What It Means for the Reader

The Body is not asked to hold its salvation by watchfulness over a covenant it was never in. The reader is asked to hear the warning for what it is, a sober word to Israel, and to rest on promises given to the Body.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 28, The Warning of Hebrews 6:4–6, reports the warning as written; this entry argues the position. Study 24, The Willful Sin Warning, and Study 46, Secure in Christ, bear on it. **Doctrinal Packets:** Hebrews.

6. Who Is the Male Child of Revelation 12:5?

THE ANSWER

The male child is the company of the 144,000, Israel's firstfruits remnant, and not the person of Christ. The child is "caught up unto God," a word of removal used of those taken up, and the same company reappears with the Lamb on mount Sion in Revelation 14:1–5 as "firstfruits." The rod of iron is shared with overcomers in Revelation 2:26–27.

Where the Verses Stand

Revelation 12 is a sign: a woman, a dragon and a child. The child's identity decides how the chapter is read. The usual answer is Christ, and the chapter does say that the child is to "rule all nations with a rod of iron." But the chapter describes what happens to the child in a way that does not match the Lord's ascension, and the book itself shows who else is called to the same rule.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
12:5–6	"And she brought forth a man child, who was to rule all nations with a rod of iron: and her child was caught up unto God, and to his throne. And the woman fled into the wilderness, where she hath a place prepared of God, that they should feed her there a thousand two hundred and threescore days."	A man child who is to rule; "caught up unto God, and to his throne." The woman flees 1,260 days.
2:26–27	"And he that overcometh, and keepeth my works unto the end, to him will I give power over the nations: And he shall rule them with a rod of iron; as the vessels of a potter shall they be broken to shivers: even as I received of my Father."	The overcomer receives "power over the nations" and rules "with a rod of iron … even as I received."
7:3–4	"Saying, Hurt not the earth, neither the sea, nor the trees, till we have sealed the servants of our God in their foreheads. And I heard the number of them which were sealed: and there were sealed an hundred and forty and four thousand of all the tribes of the children of Israel."	The sealed are "servants of our God" from the tribes of Israel.
14:1	"And I looked, and, lo, a Lamb stood on the mount Sion, and with him an hundred forty and four thousand, having his Father's name written in their foreheads."	The 144,000 stand with the Lamb on mount Sion.

14:3–5	“And they sung as it were a new song before the throne, and before the four beasts, and the elders: and no man could learn that song but the hundred and forty and four thousand, which were redeemed from the earth. These are they which were not defiled with women; for they are virgins. These are they which follow the Lamb whithersoever he goeth. These were redeemed from among men, being the firstfruits unto God and to the Lamb. And in their mouth was found no guile: for they are without fault before the throne of God.”	“Redeemed from the earth … firstfruits unto God and to the Lamb.”
1:1	“The Revelation of Jesus Christ, which God gave unto him, to shew unto his servants things which must shortly come to pass; and he sent and signified it by his angel unto his servant John:”	The book is shown to “his servants.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the child is “caught up unto God, and to his throne.” The verb is the one rendered “caught up” in 1 Thessalonians 4:17 and 2 Corinthians 12:2, a word of seizing and removal, and it is not the word used of the Lord’s ascension in the Gospels and Acts.
- **Stated:** Revelation 2:26–27 gives the rod of iron to the overcomer “even as I received of my Father.” The rule of 12:5 is therefore not reserved to the Lord alone in this book.
- **Shown by the context:** the 144,000 appear in 7:3–4 as sealed servants of Israel’s tribes and in 14:1–5 as “redeemed from among men, being the firstfruits.” A company that is sealed, kept and then seen with the Lamb on Sion is a company taken up out of the tribulation scenes.
- **Shown by the context:** the child’s removal is followed at once by the woman’s flight for 1,260 days (12:6). The child does not return in the chapter, and the chapter’s action is carried by the woman and the dragon.
- **Inferred:** that the male child is the corporate firstfruits of Israel. The text does not name the child, and the argument rests on the verb, the repetition of “firstfruits” and the rod of iron’s second use.

The Other Readings

The child is Christ. Most commentaries take the child as Christ, seeing in 12:5 the birth and ascension compressed. The reading is the common one and rests on Psalm 2 and on the compression of the Lord’s life in a single sign. It must explain why the chapter passes from birth to a rapture without a ministry, a death or a resurrection, and it must take the second use of the rod in 2:26–27 as a share in Christ’s rule that the child does not exhibit in the chapter. **The child is the 144,000.** This is the reading taken here, and it answers the question from the verb, the firstfruits and the shared rod.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
The child is Christ	A compressed picture of birth and ascension.	The verb of seizing; no ministry, death or resurrection; the rod shared in 2:26–27.
The child is the 144,000	Israel's firstfruits removed and kept.	The text does not name the child.

What It Means for the Reader

The chapter is Israel's, and the child it shows is Israel's firstfruits, not the Lord. The Body is not in view in Revelation, and a reader should not look for its gathering in a scene of the dragon and the woman.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 61, Revelation 12, and Study 23, The 144,000, report the passages as written; this entry argues the identification. **Doctrinal Packets:** Revelation.

7. Who Is “All Israel” in Romans 11:26?

THE ANSWER

“All Israel” is the nation of Israel, saved at the coming of the Deliverer, after “the fulness of the Gentiles” has come in. It is not the Body, not “spiritual Israel” and not the whole company of the elect from every nation. Romans 9–11 is spoken to Israel and concerns Israel.

Where the Verses Stand

Romans 9 to 11 turns from the Body’s standing in chapters 1 to 8 to the nation of Israel. Paul begins with grief over “my brethren, my kinsmen according to the flesh,” and ends the section with a doxology. The words “all Israel” stand at the center of the last chapter, in a passage Paul introduces as a mystery.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
11:1	“I say then, Hath God cast away his people? God forbid. For I also am an Israelite, of the seed of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin.”	Paul: “I also am an Israelite, of the seed of Abraham, of the tribe of Benjamin.”
11:11–12	“I say then, Have they stumbled that they should fall? God forbid: but rather through their fall salvation is come unto the Gentiles, for to provoke them to jealousy. Now if the fall of them be the riches of the world, and the diminishing of them the riches of the Gentiles; how much more their fulness?”	Israel’s fall is Gentile riches; “their fulness” is more.
11:25–27	“For I would not, brethren, that ye should be ignorant of this mystery, lest ye should be wise in your own conceits; that blindness in part is happened to Israel, until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in. And so all Israel shall be saved: as it is written, There shall come out of Sion the Deliverer, and shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob: For this is my covenant unto them, when I shall take away their sins.”	Blindness “in part” until the fulness of the Gentiles; “all Israel shall be saved”; the Deliverer; the covenant.
11:28–29	“As concerning the gospel, they are enemies for your sakes: but as touching the election, they are beloved for the father's sakes. For the gifts and calling of God are without repentance.”	“As touching the election, they are beloved for the father’s sakes.”

Isa 59:20–21	"And the Redeemer shall come to Zion, and unto them that turn from transgression in Jacob, saith the Lord. As for me, this is my covenant with them, saith the Lord; My spirit that is upon thee, and my words which I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth, nor out of the mouth of thy seed, nor out of the mouth of thy seed's seed, saith the Lord, from henceforth and for ever."	The Redeemer comes "to Zion, and unto them that turn from transgression in Jacob."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the blindness is "in part … to Israel," with a time limit: "until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in." The saving of "all Israel" follows that limit.
- **Stated:** the proof is from Isaiah, with the Deliverer coming "out of Sion" to turn away "ungodliness from Jacob." The name "Jacob" is the nation.
- **Shown by the context:** the word "Israel" in 11:1 is Paul's own nation, and in 11:7, 11:25 and 11:26 it is the same. Nothing in the passage marks a change of meaning at 11:26.
- **Shown by the context:** the covenant of 11:27 is "my covenant unto them," the covenant of Isaiah 59:21 given to Jacob's seed. It is Israel's covenant.
- **Inferred:** that the "mystery" of verse 25 is not the Body's mystery. It is a truth about Israel's partial blindness stated during the administration in which Paul wrote, and it concerns Israel's program. The text does not call it the mystery of Christ.

The Boundaries the Chapter Keeps

Four things govern every reading of this chapter. The olive tree is prophetic blessing, not the Body of Christ. The Gentiles in Romans 11 are prophetic participants, not Body Gentiles. The wild branches are not Body members. Grafting changes participation, not identity. Participation is not identity. Blessing is not covenant. Standing is not program membership. The wild branch is grafted in among the branches, not into Israel; it partakes of the root and fatness, but it does not become a natural branch. "Salvation is come unto the Gentiles" (11:11) means salvation, not covenant, prophetic identity or Israel's program. Any reading that turns Gentile blessing into identity transfer violates Paul's warning and collapses the distinction between Israel's program and the Body's. Identity is fixed by divine program, not by metaphor. Gentile blessing does not relocate Gentiles into Israel, and Israel's diminishing does not relocate Israel into the Body. Concurrency is operational, not transformational.

The Other Readings

All Israel is the whole elect, Jew and Gentile. N. T. Wright (*The Climax of the Covenant*) takes it as the one family of God made of Jew and Gentile. This reading has to give "Israel" a different meaning in 11:26 from that of 11:25, and it places the elect of the nations in the covenant of Isaiah 59. **All Israel is the nation, at the end.** Douglas Moo (*The Epistle to the Romans*) reads it as the nation as a whole at the end, and argues that the structure of chapters 9–11 requires it. William Hendriksen (*Israel in Prophecy*) takes it differently again, as the elect Jews of all ages, which keeps "Israel" ethnic but gathers the saved across the whole age. That is the reading taken here, and the entry adds that the passage is Israel's, not the Body's.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
The whole elect	Jew and Gentile together in one family.	“Israel” changes meaning within two verses.
The nation, saved at the end	The nation as a whole, at the Deliverer’s coming.	Whether “all” means every individual or the nation as a whole.

What It Means for the Reader

The hope of 11:26 belongs to Israel. The Body is not waiting for it, is not part of it and is not threatened by its delay. The reader is asked to wonder at God’s ways with the nation, as Paul does, and not to find the Body’s own place in an olive tree that was never planted for it.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 13, The Olive Tree and the Body of Christ, and Study 21, Israel’s Judicial Blinding. **Commentary Series:** Prophetic Identity, Volume 4 (The Olive Tree). **Doctrinal Packets:** Romans.

8. What Is the Unpardonable Sin?

THE ANSWER

It is the blasphemy against the Holy Ghost spoken in Matthew 12: the leaders' ascribing the King's works, done by the Spirit of God, to Beelzebub. It was said of Israel's generation in the presence of the King, and the sentence reaches "neither in this world, neither in the world to come." The Body cannot commit it: Paul never warns the Body of any such sin, and the Body is "sealed" by the Spirit and told it is "forgiven … all trespasses."

Where the Verses Stand

The saying comes out of one event. A man "possessed with a devil, blind, and dumb" is healed, the crowd asks whether this is the son of David, and the Pharisees answer that the Lord casts out devils "by Beelzebub the prince of the devils." The Lord's reply gives the saying about the Spirit, and Mark ends his report with the reason: "Because they said, He hath an unclean spirit."

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Mt 12:22–24	"Then was brought unto him one possessed with a devil, blind, and dumb: and he healed him, insomuch that the blind and dumb both spake and saw. And all the people were amazed, and said, Is not this the son of David? But when the Pharisees heard it, they said, This fellow doth not cast out devils, but by Beelzebub the prince of the devils."	The healing; "the son of David?"; the Pharisees: by Beelzebub.
Mt 12:28	"But if I cast out devils by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God is come unto you."	"By the Spirit of God … the kingdom of God is come unto you."
Mt 12:31–32	"Wherefore I say unto you, All manner of sin and blasphemy shall be forgiven unto men: but the blasphemy against the Holy Ghost shall not be forgiven unto men. And whosoever speaketh a word against the Son of man, it shall be forgiven him: but whosoever speaketh against the Holy Ghost, it shall not be forgiven him, neither in this world, neither in the world to come."	All sin forgiven but the blasphemy against the Holy Ghost; "neither in this world, neither in the world to come."
Mk 3:28–30	"Verily I say unto you, All sins shall be forgiven unto the sons of men, and blasphemies wherewith soever they shall blaspheme: But he that shall blaspheme against the Holy Ghost hath never forgiveness, but is in danger of eternal damnation. Because they said, He hath an unclean spirit."	"Because they said, He hath an unclean spirit."

Col 2:13	"And you, being dead in your sins and the uncircumcision of your flesh, hath he quickened together with him, having forgiven you all trespasses;"	To the Body: "having forgiven you all trespasses."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Mark gives the reason in his own words: "Because they said, He hath an unclean spirit." The blasphemy is the saying, and the saying is about the Lord's works.
- **Stated:** the Lord gives the ground in 12:28: he casts out devils "by the Spirit of God," and the sign is "the kingdom of God is come unto you." To say the Spirit's work is Satan's is to say the kingdom's sign is Satan's.
- **Shown by the context:** the contrast is between a word against "the Son of man," which may be forgiven, and a word against the Spirit, which is not. The King stands before them in humility, and they may mistake him; they cannot mistake the Spirit's work and call it the devil's.
- **Shown by the context:** the setting is Israel's generation and its age. "This world" and "the world to come" are Israel's two ages, and the sentence closes both to that generation's leaders as they stood.
- **Inferred:** that the sin was committed by Israel's leaders during the King's earthly ministry, when his kingdom signs were being done. The argument rests on the setting and the ground the Lord gives, and on the silence of Paul's letters: none warns the Body of such a sin, and Ephesians 1:13–14 says the Body is sealed with the Holy Spirit of promise.

The Other Readings

Persistent, hardened rejection of the Spirit's witness. Many commentaries and pastoral works take the sin as a willful, malicious rejection of the Spirit's work that may be done in any age. It gives comfort, since the person who fears he has done it shows the opposite. It must explain why Mark gives a single historical saying as the reason. **A sin tied to Christ's presence.** Some hold that the sin could be committed only while the Lord was present on earth, so that it cannot be committed now. That is the reading taken here, and the entry adds that the setting is Israel's and that the Body is sealed.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Hardened rejection in any age	A willful rejection of the Spirit's witness.	Mark's reason is one saying, tied to one event.
Tied to the King's presence	The saying needs the King and his works before them.	The text does not state a date for its end.

What It Means for the Reader

The person who fears he has committed this sin may rest on what the text says. The sin was a saying made against the Spirit's works in the presence of the King, by Israel's leaders, and the Body is sealed and is told that all its trespasses are forgiven.

Related Reading

Commentary Series: Gospel, Volume 2 (The Lord's Ministry to Israel). **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew and Mark.

9. Who Are “the Sons of God” in Genesis 6:1–4?

THE ANSWER

The sons of God are angelic beings. The same title is used of them in Job 1:6 and 38:7, and Peter and Jude set angels who sinned beside the flood and Sodom. The Lord’s words in Matthew 22:30 describe people in the resurrection and do not decide what angels could do before.

Where the Verses Stand

Genesis 6 begins the account of the flood. It opens with the multiplying of men, the sons of God and the daughters of men, and it ends with a statement of violence and the flood decree. The identity of the sons of God is the question that decides what the passage is describing.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Gen 6:1–4	“And it came to pass, when men began to multiply on the face of the earth, and daughters were born unto them, That the sons of God saw the daughters of men that they were fair; and they took them wives of all which they chose. And the Lord said, My spirit shall not always strive with man, for that he also is flesh: yet his days shall be an hundred and twenty years. There were giants in the earth in those days; and also after that, when the sons of God came in unto the daughters of men, and they bare children to them, the same became mighty men which were of old, men of renown.”	“The sons of God” take wives of “the daughters of men.” “Giants in the earth.”
Gen 6:5–7	“And God saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every imagination of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually. And it repented the Lord that he had made man on the earth, and it grieved him at his heart. And the Lord said, I will destroy man whom I have created from the face of the earth; both man, and beast, and the creeping thing, and the fowls of the air; for it repenteth me that I have made them.”	The wickedness of man; the decision to destroy.
Job 1:6	“Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the Lord, and Satan came also among them.”	“The sons of God came to present themselves before the Lord, and Satan came also.”
Job 38:7	“When the morning stars sang together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy?”	“All the sons of God shouted for joy” at the creation.

Mt 22:30	“For in the resurrection they neither marry, nor are given in marriage, but are as the angels of God in heaven.”	In the resurrection people are “as the angels of God in heaven.”
2 Pet 2:4–5	“For if God spared not the angels that sinned, but cast them down to hell, and delivered them into chains of darkness, to be reserved unto judgment; And spared not the old world, but saved Noah the eighth person, a preacher of righteousness, bringing in the flood upon the world of the ungodly;”	God “spared not the angels that sinned”; he “spared not the old world.”
Jude 6–7	“And the angels which kept not their first estate, but left their own habitation, he hath reserved in everlasting chains under darkness unto the judgment of the great day. Even as Sodom and Gomorrha, and the cities about them in like manner, giving themselves over to fornication, and going after strange flesh, are set forth for an example, suffering the vengeance of eternal fire.”	Angels “left their own habitation”; “even as Sodom … going after strange flesh.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** in the Old Testament, the Hebrew phrase translated “sons of God” is used of beings who present themselves before the Lord (Job 1:6) and who watched creation (Job 38:7). Those beings are not men.
- **Stated:** Peter sets “the angels that sinned” beside “the old world” in the flood (2 Peter 2:4–5), and Jude joins angels who “left their own habitation” to Sodom’s “strange flesh” (Jude 6–7).
- **Shown by the context:** the passage says the sons of God “saw the daughters of men” and “took them wives of all which they chose.” The contrast is between the two groups, and the text treats the sons of God as a distinct order from “men.”
- **Shown by the context:** the Lord’s words in Matthew 22:30 describe how people will be in the resurrection: “as the angels … in heaven.” He speaks of holy angels in heaven and says nothing of fallen angels on the earth, and the comparison is to the people’s state.
- **Inferred:** that Peter and Jude have this event in view. Neither names Genesis 6, and the argument rests on the pairing of the angels with the flood and with “strange flesh.”

The Other Readings

The line of Seth. Gleason Archer (*Encyclopedia of Bible Difficulties*) holds that the sons of God are the godly line of Seth who married the line of Cain. It fits the interest of Genesis 4–5 in two lines, and it must explain why the children of such marriages were “mighty men” and why Job’s “sons of God” are not Sethites. **Human rulers.** Meredith Kline (“Divine Kingship and Genesis 6:1–4”) takes them as dynastic kings who practised polygamy. **Angelic beings.** Gordon Wenham (*Genesis 1–15*, Word Biblical Commentary) takes them as divine beings. That is the reading taken here.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
The line of Seth	Godly men marry the line of Cain.	“Sons of God” in Job 1 and 38.
Human rulers	Dynastic kings take many wives.	The same phrase elsewhere is not used of men.
Angelic beings	Heavenly beings take wives.	Matthew 22:30 is read against it; the text does not describe the mechanism.

What It Means for the Reader

The passage does not tell the reader how the union happened or what was born of it, and it does not build a doctrine of angels on the point. It tells the reader why the earth’s wickedness was “great” before the flood, and that God judged it.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 79, The Realms of the Dead, reports 2 Peter 2:4 and Jude 6 as written. **Doctrinal Packets:** Genesis and Jude.

10. What Does “Baptized for the Dead” Mean in 1 Corinthians 15:29?

THE ANSWER

It names a practice of some at Corinth, spoken of as “they,” and Paul uses it as an argument without commending it or commanding it. The passage is part of his proof that the dead rise. The Body has no ordinance of baptism on behalf of the dead.

Where the Verses Stand

First Corinthians 15 answers some at Corinth who said “there is no resurrection of the dead.” Paul argues from Christ’s rising, then asks what follows if the dead do not rise. The question about baptism for the dead is followed by Paul’s own case: “why stand we in jeopardy every hour?”

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
15:12–13	“Now if Christ be preached that he rose from the dead, how say some among you that there is no resurrection of the dead? But if there be no resurrection of the dead, then is Christ not risen:”	Some say there is no resurrection; then Christ is not risen.
15:29–30	“Else what shall they do which are baptized for the dead, if the dead rise not at all? why are they then baptized for the dead? And why stand we in jeopardy every hour?”	“Else what shall they do which are baptized for the dead”; “why stand we in jeopardy?”
15:31–32	“I protest by your rejoicing which I have in Christ Jesus our Lord, I die daily. If after the manner of men I have fought with beasts at Ephesus, what advantageth it me, if the dead rise not? let us eat and drink; for to morrow we die.”	“I die daily”; “what advantageth it me, if the dead rise not?”
12:13	“For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body, whether we be Jews or Gentiles, whether we be bond or free; and have been all made to drink into one Spirit.”	“By one Spirit are we all baptized into one body.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Paul speaks of the baptized “for the dead” as “they.” In the next verse he turns to “we,” asking why he and his companions stand in danger. The practice is placed outside the “we” of the apostle’s own company.
- **Stated:** Paul asks what “they” will do “if the dead rise not at all.” The practice is brought forward as something that makes no sense on the denial of the resurrection, not as a rule.
- **Shown by the context:** the whole chapter is an argument for the resurrection, and verse 29 stands in the series of arguments (verses 29–32) from what is done: baptism for the dead, Paul’s own danger, his fighting “with beasts at Ephesus.”
- **Shown by the context:** Paul’s own statement of the baptism that makes the Body is in 12:13: “by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body.” That baptism is not for another person.

- **Inferred:** that the practice was a proxy baptism done by some Corinthians for dead believers. The text does not describe the practice, and the argument rests on the natural reading of “for the dead” and the “they.”

The Other Readings

A proxy baptism practised by some, not approved. The natural reading of the words is a vicarious baptism done by some in Corinth, which Paul mentions without approval. That is the reading taken here. **A wide range of other proposals.** Anthony Thiselton (*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*, New International Greek Testament Commentary) surveys dozens of proposals, among them baptism in the hope of joining the dead, baptism in the place of those who died, and baptism taken as suffering. Each must explain the preposition “for” and the unexplained “they.”

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Proxy baptism practised by some	Some at Corinth are baptized for dead persons; Paul reports it.	The text does not describe it.
Baptism in hope of the resurrection	Baptism taken “for” the sake of the dead’s rising.	Strains “for the dead” and the “they.”

What It Means for the Reader

The reader should not take from the verse a ceremony for the dead. Paul’s gospel offers no baptism by proxy, and the single baptism he gives the Body is the Spirit’s. The verse is there to show that without the resurrection, much of what believers do makes no sense.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 49, The Resurrections of Scripture, and Study 42, One Baptism.
Doctrinal Packets: 1 Corinthians.

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